atmosphere. The transponder, during the fall and after, would transmit the data to us.

Kalam was the project director and I, the controller. Heads of various systems communicate through the controller who also does the countdown. I was in the block house, a virtual concrete bunker a few metres from the rocket, to have a close view of the launch. About ten minutes before the lift-off, I saw something peculiar: the nose cone, which was to eject at 63 km altitude had already been ejected.

'Controller calling project director,' I announced.

Kalam responded.

'Nose cone got ejected.'

'What?'

'The nose cone has been ejected.'

TERLS director Murthy, who was listening in from the system in his office, asked me to come on the phone. I explained to him what I saw.

'But how can it eject on ground?' he wanted to know. 'It was to happen at 63 km'

It was then that we found that the squib which was to fire at the pre-determined high altitude was activated early, probably because of electromagnetic emission from the surrounding radars on ground. Lesson learned: Squibs should be tested for what we call 'no-fire current', the threshold of the squib to resist triggering through electric current generated by electromagnetic frequency.

The launch was aborted.

Aravamudan, one of the early birds at TERLS, was a man who never lost his cool even during tense moments. His wisecracks, in fact, lightened up such moments.

After the nose cone ejection, I announced: 'Controller calling. Director wants a discussion.'

Kalam replied, 'Which station is this?'

Aravamudan quipped, 'Kazhakkoottam police station.'

At the discussion, P P Kale, head of a group, asked who had developed the ejection mechanism. Someone said Kalam. Kale pulled Kalam's leg,